

Song Lab

Hear chords, build beats, and map your song. Scan the code or type:

cmfnyc.github.io/song-lab/



Using おんぷノート (Onpu Note) for Songwriting

おんぷノート is Kawai's free notation app for school iPads. You write notes with a finger or stylus and the app turns them into clean notation. Then it plays them back.

It's great for **writing a melody down and hearing it**. It wasn't built for songwriting, so a few jobs happen outside the app. This page shows how.

What it does well

- **Handwriting input:** write notes on the staff and the app converts them
- **Instant playback**, even before a bar is finished
- **34 instrument sounds** (try piano, flute, strings, or a synth-like sound for a pop lead)
- **Tempo slider** for playback speed
- **Treble and bass clef**, key signatures, time signatures, ties, dotted notes, rests
- **PDF export** to Files, iCloud Drive, or Google Drive

What it can't do (and what to do instead)

It can't...	Do this instead
Save more than one score	Export a PDF at the end of every session, before starting anything new
Show chord names	Keep a chord chart on paper with bar numbers that match the score
Hold lyrics	Write lyrics on paper with one dash per note (see Lyric Toolkit)
Export MIDI to GarageBand	Play the melody in on a GarageBand keyboard, reading your score
Print	Export the PDF and print it from Files

Rule 1: One score at a time → PDF every session

The app only keeps one score. Starting a new one can replace the old one.

At the end of **every** session:

1. Export the score as a **PDF**.
2. Name it with the course pattern: `S1-[title]-chorus-melody-v1.pdf`
3. Save it to a folder **you** control (iCloud Drive or Google Drive). School iPads can be reset or managed by the school, so keep your own copy.

Before writing a bassline or starting Song 2, check that the current melody PDF is saved. Then clear the score and start the new part.

Rule 2: Chords live on a chord chart

Since the app has no chord names, keep a simple chart beside the iPad. Number the bars to match the score:

Bar:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
Chord:	C	G	Am	F	C	G	Am	F
Notes:	CEG	GBD	ACE	FAC	CEG	GBD	ACE	FAC

The **Notes** row is the key part. It lets you check the melody by eye: **the note on beat 1 of each bar should usually be one of that bar's chord notes**.

Rule 3: Check the melody against the chords by ear

The app plays the melody but not the chords. Two ways to hear them together:

- **Producer plays chords:** set the playback tempo slow. You (or he) play the chord chart on the instrument while the app plays the melody.

- **Play it into GarageBand (best):** he plays the melody on a GarageBand keyboard track over his groove, reading from the score. It's great sight-reading practice, and now the melody is in the song.
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Rule 4: Getting the melody into GarageBand

There's no MIDI export, so:

1. **Play it in (recommended).** In GarageBand, add a Keyboard track, pick a lead sound, turn on the metronome, and play the melody from the score. Slow the song tempo down to record if needed, then speed it back up. GarageBand keeps it in time. On the Mac, fix wrong notes afterward in the piano roll.
 2. **Record the playback (backup).** If おんぷノート is on the school iPad and GarageBand is on a different device, hold the iPad near the other device's mic and record the playback. The app's tempo slider isn't set in exact BPM, so this can drift out of time with the beat. Treat it as a sketch, not a final track.
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Rule 5: The lead sheet is a marked-up PDF

A lead sheet shows melody, chord names above the staff, and lyrics below. To make one:

1. Export the finished melody as a PDF.
 2. Open it in the **Files** app and tap the **Markup** (pen) button.
 3. Handwrite the **chord names** above the staff at the start of each bar.
 4. Handwrite the **lyrics** under the notes, one syllable per note.
 5. Add the **title** and "**Music and lyrics by [name]**" at the top.
 6. Tap **Done** and save it as `S1-[title]-LEAD-SHEET.pdf`.
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Handwriting tips

- **Zoom in** before writing so noteheads land clearly on a line or space.
- A **stylus** (Apple Pencil or any iPad stylus) is much more accurate than a finger.
- Write **one bar, then play it back**. Catch recognition mistakes early.

- If a note is recognized wrong, erase it and write it again, a little bigger.
 - Set the **key signature** and **time signature (4/4)** first. Then you'll need fewer sharps and flats.
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Setting the tempo

The playback speed is a slider, not a BPM number. Match it by ear: play the GarageBand metronome at the song's BPM, then move the slider until the app's playback feels the same speed.

If he outgrows it

If he wants chord symbols, lyrics, many saved scores, or MIDI export, these free or freemium options are worth a look. Check that they suit the device first.

- **GarageBand on Mac:** its score view shows notation for any keyboard part he plays in.
- **Flat** (flat.io) or **Noteflight** (noteflight.com): browser-based notation with chord symbols and lyrics. Their free tiers limit how many scores you can keep.